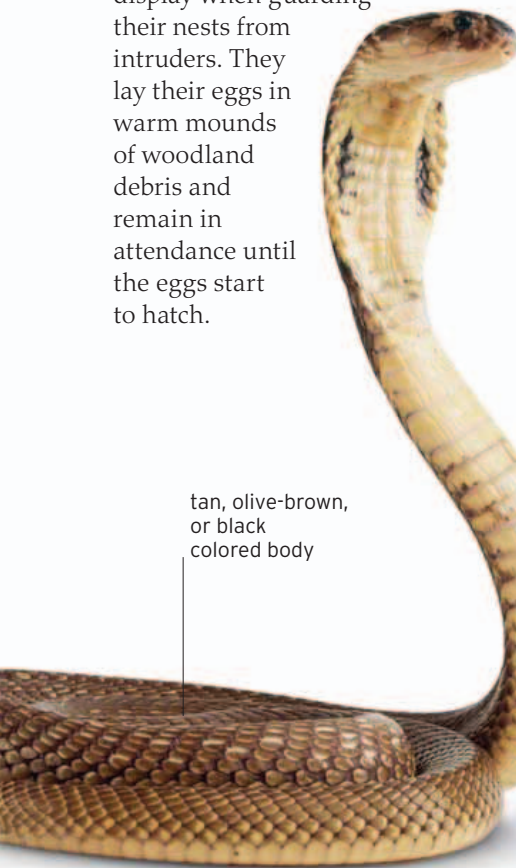


King cobra

Ophiophagus hannah

- ↔ 10–16 ft (3–5 m)
- 📍 S. and SE. Asia
- ⊗ Vulnerable

The world's longest venomous snake is also a specialist hunter of other snakes. Like other cobras, it rears up when threatened, but its hood is narrower than that of other cobras. Females have an especially aggressive threat display when guarding their nests from intruders. They lay their eggs in warm mounds of woodland debris and remain in attendance until the eggs start to hatch.



tan, olive-brown, or black colored body

Puff adder

Bitis arietans

- ↔ 3–6 ft (1–1.8 m)
- 📍 Sub-Saharan Africa
- ⊗ Not known

This ground-dwelling, highly venomous snake, often found near human habitations, is responsible for more fatal bites in Africa than any other species. It is a well-camouflaged, thick-bodied snake and, when threatened, it hisses and puffs before striking with considerable force. Like most other members of the viper family, this species bears live young, sometimes producing litters of more than 100—more than any other snake.

Southern copperhead

Agkistrodon contortrix

- ↔ 24–51 in (61–130 cm)
- 📍 C. and SE. US
- ⊗ Common

This woodland snake hunts in the dark, targeting warm-blooded prey, such as rodents, using heat-seeking sensory “pits” on the sides of its head. Like other pit vipers, it waits for prey to approach within striking range before attacking. Its venom, although fatal to small animals, is less dangerous to humans than that of related species.

Gaboon viper

Bitis gabonica

- ↔ 4–7 ft (1.2–2.1 m)
- 📍 W. and C. Africa
- ⊗ Not known

A massive head and bulky body make the gaboon viper the world's heaviest venomous snake. It also has the biggest fangs of any snake—and delivers the greatest volume of venom. Its coloration and patterning camouflage it perfectly against the leaf litter of its woodland habitat. It strikes with lightning speed and keeps a hold of its victim, killing prey up to the size of small antelopes.



geometric patterning

triangular head

Sidewinder

Crotalus cerastes

- ↔ 18–32 in (45–80 cm)
- 📍 SW. US, NW. Mexico
- ⊗ Locally common

The “side-winding” form of locomotion—where the snake moves in a diagonal direction with two parts of its body touching the ground at any one time—is a specialized technique used for moving quickly on unstable, shifting sand. The sidewinder, a species of rattlesnake, hunts desert rodents. Like other vipers, it is an ambusher—and attacks prey from the cover of clumps of shrubby vegetation.



South American bushmaster

Lachesis muta

- ↔ 8–12 ft (2.4–3.7 m)
- 📍 S. Central America, N. South America
- ⊗ Not known

Widespread in forests and open country, the bushmaster is the longest venomous snake in the Americas. It exhibits the tail-shaking behavior of rattlesnakes when threatened, but lacks their noisy rattle. Like other pit vipers, it hunts warm-blooded animals, but differs from most by laying eggs instead of giving birth to live young.

Texas thread snake

Rena dulcis

- ↔ 6–11 in (15–30 cm)
- 📍 S. US, NE. Mexico
- ⊗ Locally common

This earthwormlike snake has smooth skin and scale-covered eyes as adaptations for burrowing through the soil. It is one of nearly 300 species of superficially similar thread and blind snakes—a group that includes the world's smallest snake. It uses its tiny mouth to hunt underground ants and termites, and even releases a pheromone that pacifies the insects so it can invade their nests unmolested.

Other species

- Asian tiger keelback
Rhabdophis tigrinus » p291
- Black mamba
Dendroaspis polylepis » p207
- Cape cobra
Naja nivea » p234
- Common adder
Vipera berus » p145
- Common garter snake
Thamnophis sirtalis » p50
- Emerald tree boa
Corallus caninus » p97
- Giant parrot snake
Leptophis ahaetulla » p105
- Green anaconda
Eunectes murinus » p105
- Indian cobra
Naja naja » p264

- Mojave rattlesnake
Crotalus scutulatus » p65
- Mountain kingsnake
Lampropeltis zonata » p59
- Turtle-headed seasnake
Emydocephalus annulatus » p347
- Woma python
Aspidites ramsayi » p333